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New York

President:	Mr. Mukongo	(Democratic Republic of the Congo)
Members:	Bahrain	Mr. Alrowaiei
	China	Mr. Sun Lei
	Colombia	Mrs. Zalabata Torres
	Denmark	Ms. Lassen
	France	Mr. Bonnafont
	Greece	Mrs. Balta
	Latvia	Ms. Pavļuta-Deslandes
	Liberia	Mr. Brown II
	Pakistan	Mr. Ahmad
	Panama	Mr. Alfaro de Alba
	Russian Federation	Ms. Evstigneeva
	Somalia	Mr. Abdullahi
	United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland	Ms. Jambert-Gray
	United States of America	Mr. Bartos

Agenda

Peace consolidation in West Africa

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The meeting was called to order at 10.45 a.m.

Adoption of the agenda

The agenda was adopted.

Peace consolidation in West Africa

The President (*spoke in French*): In accordance with rule 37 of the Council's provisional rules of procedure, I invite the representatives of Burkina Faso and Côte d'Ivoire to participate in this meeting.

In accordance with rule 39 of the Council's provisional rules of procedure, I invite Mr. Leonardo Santos Simão, Special Representative of the Secretary-General and Head of the United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel, to participate in this meeting.

The Security Council will now begin its consideration of the item on its agenda.

I now give the floor to Mr. Simão.

Mr. Simão (*spoke in French*): I have the honour to present to the Council the report of the Secretary-General on the activities of the United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel (UNOWAS) (S/2026/537).

Allow me at the outset to extend my sincerest congratulations to the Democratic Republic of the Congo on presiding over the Council's proceedings for the month of July and to wish it a successful presidency.

A summit of the Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS) is to be held on 19 July in Sierra Leone. Its purpose is twofold, being both routine in nature but also focused on charting the future of regional integration in West Africa, following recent political developments in the area. In a region in the grip of heightened geopolitical tensions, which are compounding the already fragile security situation, we are committed to promoting dialogue, fostering mutual understanding, conveying messages of encouragement and seeking common ground among all stakeholders, that is to say, government leaders, regional institutions, United Nations bodies, civil society, women and youth leaders.

(*spoke in English*)

In West Africa and the Sahel, three broad trends stand out: first the concerning security situation; secondly, the renewal of the momentum for dialogue and cooperation; and thirdly, the democratic developments occurring in the region.

As regards the security situation, the threat posed by terrorists and other non-State armed groups remains acute, especially in the central Sahel and northern Nigeria, and they are rapidly targeting coastal States in the Gulf of Guinea. These groups are adapting their tactics, increasingly using advanced technology such as drones, means of communication and cryptocurrencies. Their attacks are coordinated across multiple fronts, including across countries. Their actions intersect with transnational international organized crime and are aimed at consolidating territorial and economic control and at eroding public confidence in State authority, with serious damage to social cohesion.

On 25 April, a coalition of the terrorist group Jama'a Nusrat ul-Islam wa al-Muslimin (JNIM) and the Malian separatist group the Front de Libération de l'Azawad (FLA) launched simultaneous attacks against strategic targets in Bamako, Kati, Kidal, Gao and Mopti among others, causing civilian and military casualties, including the death of the Minister of Defence. A partial blockade imposed on key supply routes into Bamako is disrupting the movement of essential goods and

services, and attacks on power lines are affecting the supply of electricity and water. More recently, fighting between the Malian armed forces and the FLA/JNIM coalition has moved into northern Mali, especially in the Kidal and Gao regions.

In the Niger, terrorist attacks occurred at the Niamey airport, as well as against a military base in Tahoua, between January and June. Attacks have also been reported in Tillabéri and Diffa regions.

Burkina Faso continued to face assaults, including drone-enabled operations, particularly in the North and East regions. The authorities announced plans to recruit 100,000 reservists and approximately 12,000 military personnel by the end of 2026. In Nigeria, the North and the Middle Belt also experienced continued attacks, abductions and many civilian casualties.

The human cost of the violence is devastating. As of the end of February, about 6.8 million people were internally displaced across the region, in addition to around 1.28 million refugees and asylum seekers, including approximately 220,000 in Benin, Côte d'Ivoire, Ghana and Togo. In Liberia, authorities report a steep increase in the migrant population of Burkinabe since 2025, from about 40,000 to around 140,000 today. This is placing great pressure on host communities, land resources and basic social services.

Coupled with terrorism, drug trafficking, production and consumption are a rapidly growing phenomenon in the region, affecting mainly coastal States, in which increasing quantities of different types of these substances are being seized by the authorities. Youth are the principal victims, but there are also reports of their use by terrorist combatants. Furthermore, political and public institutions in some countries are reportedly threatened by drug syndicates, weakening them.

Humanitarian access remains severely constrained in many areas, while funding shortfalls are reducing the reach of life-saving assistance. Women, children and young people continue to bear the brunt of displacement, insecurity, rights violations and limited access to essential services. Attacks on schools underscore the wider toll that insecurity is taking on the future prospects of entire communities. However, new investments in school and vocational training infrastructure, as well as alternative learning methods, are helping keep education within reach for vulnerable or displaced children and youth, including girls, in hard-to-reach areas.

Faced with these challenges, regional actors are working hard to find solutions. ECOWAS has renewed efforts to operationalize its Standby Force, but at a lower scale than needed, due to financial limitations. The implementation of resolution 2719 (2023) was expected to be a major United Nations contribution in assisting the region to face the growing challenge of terrorism.

(*spoke in French*)

West Africa and the Sahel are experiencing a new wave of dialogue. A High-Level Consultative Conference on Regional Cooperation and Security, held in Accra in January, brought together regional leaders and partners who committed to rebuilding trust and establishing a new security cooperation mechanism to replace the Accra Initiative. Further consultations have since taken place, involving new stakeholders, notably from Europe and other regions, with the active participation of all member States of the Confederation of Sahel States and ECOWAS.

In the same vein, ECOWAS has appointed Guinea's former Prime Minister, Lansana Kouyaté, as chief negotiator responsible for dialogue with the Confederation of Sahel States countries, and consultations are now under way. Furthermore, actors such as Senegal and Togo are increasing initiatives to bridge differences and promote a common strategy to combat the scourge of terrorism and organized crime in the

region. It is also worth highlighting the growing role of the African Union (AU), which is playing an increasingly important role in promoting dialogue, bringing the parties closer together and ensuring strategic coherence. This development is reflected in particular in enhanced cooperation with ECOWAS, as well as in increased exchanges with Mali and other countries of the region.

(*spoke in English*)

UNOWAS has remained fully engaged in encouraging and supporting these developments for dialogue and cooperation. During the reporting period, I consulted leaders and senior officials across the region, including in Ghana, Togo, the Niger and Senegal, as well as with ECOWAS, the AU and European envoys, together with international partners in Abuja, Brussels, Washington and Paris. Convening regional and international actors in Banjul in April, the AU Special Representative and Head of the AU Mission for Mali and the Sahel, Mamadou Tangara, presented the Mission's new approach, built around respect for sovereignty, unconditional dialogue and inclusive institutional engagement.

These exchanges show that there is a shift from confrontation towards collaboration and constructive engagement that is beginning to produce concrete results. On 9 February, the Niger and Nigeria reopened the Kamba border crossing, restoring a significant trade corridor. The attendance by the Prime Minister of the Niger, as well as the Foreign Ministers of Burkina Faso and Mali, at the inauguration of President Romuald Wadagni of Benin and President Wadagni's subsequent tour to Niamey, Ouagadougou and Bamako and the broader Sahel, signalled a renewed commitment to improving relations. Talks are ongoing for the reopening of the Niger-Benin border.

The Mano River Union also stepped up its engagement for dialogue, as the Presidents of Guinea, Liberia and Sierra Leone met in Conakry to address growing tensions in their border areas and recommit to peaceful dispute resolution. In Sierra Leone, mediation by the International Moral Guarantors, including ECOWAS and UNOWAS, helped secure an agreement between the Government and the opposition on key steps to accelerate the implementation of the Agreement for National Unity and the recommendations of the Tripartite Committee. More recently, Mali and Algeria decided to normalize their bilateral relations by opening their respective airspaces and to reinstate their ambassadors.

These are some examples of regional efforts towards dialogue leading to cooperation among the countries of the region.

Although facing multiple challenges, democracy is taking root in the region, as reflected by peaceful elections, reforms and continued steps towards accountable governance. During the reporting period, elections proceeded peacefully in Benin, Cabo Verde, Côte d'Ivoire and Guinea. In Cabo Verde, the opposition returned to power after a decade, while in Benin, the April presidential election concluded the 2026 electoral cycle.

Reform efforts are also under way in several countries. In Ghana, the establishment of a Specialized High Court Division to expedite corruption, illegal mining and asset recovery cases is a significant step towards strengthening accountability. In the Gambia, the appointment of a special prosecutor and the establishment of a special criminal division in the High Court constitute a positive step towards ensuring transitional justice. In Senegal, following national dialogues in 2024 and 2025, reform efforts have continued, including the ongoing constitutional reform. In Mauritania, a national dialogue is on the agenda.

In several countries, especially in the central Sahel, authorities have introduced new regulatory frameworks for the exercise of political and civic freedoms and the functioning of associations and public actors. These measures reflect, in part, an intention by the authorities to strengthen State authority during a period of transition and heightened insecurity, although anxieties and criticisms by political parties and civil society groups are mounting. While timelines for a return to constitutional order remain unclear in the three central Sahel States, there remains a need to ensure stability, accountability and the rule of law, along with respect for human rights and inclusive governance.

Security responses alone will not be sufficient. To successfully address the root causes of instability, investments are needed in the social, economic and environmental foundations of peace. That is why UNOWAS has continued to work across a range of regional priorities. In January, we convened a dialogue on water diplomacy with the region's major basin organizations, United Nations entities and regional institutions, reaffirming water cooperation as a tool for conflict prevention, climate resilience and regional integration ahead of the 2026 United Nations Water Conference. We have also continued to support the implementation of the Yaoundé maritime security architecture, recognizing that insecurity on land and insecurity at sea are part of the same wider ecosystem of organized crime and illicit trafficking. Together with the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime, we also convened a dialogue between youth and government authorities in Dakar on emerging drugs, youth and security, highlighting the growing risks posed by the proliferation of new drugs and their implications for social cohesion, public health and terrorism financing.

We have also seen positive examples of holistic national action to address the root causes of some of these challenges. In northern Togo, I was able to witness the positive impact on security of combining security measures with development and humanitarian interventions, led by the Government, with United Nations support.

This year, the economy of the region is projected to grow by approximately 5 per cent on average, with strong growth in countries such as Benin, Côte d'Ivoire, Guinea, the Niger, the Gambia and Senegal. However, domestic and external debt burdens, inflation, national security expenditures, shrinking fiscal space and external shocks continue to mitigate the social impact of these gains. Fighting poverty and vulnerability must therefore remain a common objective in the broader fight against terrorism.

The Cameroon-Nigeria Mixed Commission is in the final phase of implementing the judgment of the International Court of Justice of 2002, with steps towards demarcating the last 36 km of the border under preparation. This is an example of how patient and principled engagement can transform potentially divisive issues into a framework for cooperation. In a related development, Ghana's decision to refer its maritime dispute with Togo to arbitration under the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea is another welcome affirmation that international law is a viable and constructive path to peaceful dispute settlement.

UNOWAS remains fully committed to implementing its mandate in support of peace, constitutional governance and regional cooperation in West Africa and the Sahel. Following the letter of the President of the Security Council of 19 February (S/2026/83), welcoming the Secretary-General's decision to conduct an independent strategic review of the mandate and activities of UNOWAS, the review process has started, led by the former President of the Federal Democratic Republic of Ethiopia, Ms. Sahle-Work Zewde. We look forward to its conclusions and recommendations as an important contribution to make UNOWAS more adapted to evolving realities in

West Africa and the Sahel and consolidate the relevance of the United Nations in the region.

In concluding, I want to express our gratitude for the support that UNOWAS continues to receive from the Council.

The President (*spoke in French*): I thank Mr. Simão for his briefing.

I shall now give the floor to those members of the Council who wish to make statements.

Mr. Brown II (Liberia): I have the honour to deliver this statement on behalf of the three African members of the Security Council (A3), namely, the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Somalia and my own country, Liberia.

We thank the Special Representative of the Secretary-General and Head of the United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel (UNOWAS) for his sobering yet clear-eyed briefing, and we welcome the extension of the UNOWAS mandate until January 2029. This is a vote of confidence in preventive diplomacy, at the very moment that the region needs it most.

West Africa and the Sahel stand at a crossroads between peril and promise. The A3 chooses the road of promise, in unwavering solidarity with the countries and peoples of the region, whose resilience remains its greatest resource. But we do not, and will not, look away from the peril. The A3 condemns in the strongest terms the coordinated terrorist attacks of 25 April across Mali and the assault on Niamey's international airport in June, and we extend our condolences to the bereaved families and affected Governments. The growing sophistication of non-State armed groups, their tactical use of drones and specialized improvised explosive devices, the cross-border flow of advanced weaponry and the deepening convergence of terrorism with transnational organized crime demand a response equal to the threat that they pose.

Terror knows no borders; neither must our cooperation against it. We must act decisively to prevent spillover into coastal States and adjacent maritime corridors. Yet, the A3 has said it before and will say it again: there is no military solution to these crises. Lasting peace must be built by addressing root causes — poverty, exclusion, governance deficits and climate vulnerability — for a battlefield victory that leaves despair intact is no victory at all.

The A3 remains a steadfast champion of regional ownership and African solutions. We welcome the orderly conduct of recent elections in Benin, Cabo Verde, Côte d'Ivoire and Guinea, and we especially salute Cabo Verde's peaceful transfer of power, a reminder that democratic alternation is not the exception in our region but the common practice, or at least the growing common practice. We equally commend the vigilance of national forces and the decisive support of the Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS) in preserving constitutional order in Benin last December. When constitutional order was tested, the West African region answered. In the same spirit, we also warmly welcome the appointment of chief negotiator Lansana Kouyaté to lead the dialogue between ECOWAS and the Confederation of Sahel States. Bridges are harder to build than walls, but they are the only structures that carry us forward and across. We urge all parties to seize this opportunity in good faith. Furthermore, the A3 calls for the full implementation of resolution 2719 (2023) as a pathway towards predictable and sustainable financing for African-led peace operations.

Behind every statistic we have heard in the Secretary-General's report (S/2026/537) is a human face. The humanitarian situation remains dire, driven by conflict, mass displacement and climate shocks, while humanitarian needs and response plans remain severely underfunded. We call upon the international

community to scale up assistance through predictable, flexible financing, and we stress the systematic integration of gender-responsive indicators and the principles of the Safe Schools Declaration because a child kept safely in school today is a conflict prevented tomorrow.

Amid these challenges, the Council should also lift up what works. The Cameroon-Nigeria Mixed Commission, as we have heard, with more than 2,000 kilometres of boundary agreed and the validation of boundary coordinates achieved, stands as a testament to what patient legal diplomacy can accomplish. As the Commission advances towards the finalization of demarcation and transition to national ownership, it offers the Council and our continent a gold standard template that is worth replicating. Meanwhile, the A3 welcomes the ongoing independent strategic review of UNOWAS from which a report is expected in September. We encourage a forward-looking outcome that keeps the office fit for purpose and deepens its partnerships with the African Union, ECOWAS and the Confederation of Sahel States.

In conclusion, the A3 reaffirms its full support for UNOWAS and its preventive diplomacy mandate. We stand ready to work constructively with all Council members on concrete outcomes developed in close alignment with and full respect for the consent and ownership of the States of the region. The peoples of West Africa and the Sahel are not asking the world to carry them. They — I should say we — are asking the world to walk with us. The A3 will walk with them every step of the way.

Ms. Lassen (Denmark): Let me thank the Special Representative to the Secretary-General Simão for his insightful briefing.

I have three points to raise.

First, Denmark is deeply concerned about the continued worsening of the security situation in West Africa and the Sahel. In the Central Sahel, attacks occur on a daily basis, with a high number of civilian victims. In Mali last April, a large coordinated attack threatened the stability of the State. Armed violence is also spreading to the broader region. In Nigeria, we have seen a range of heinous attacks on schools. Against this backdrop, a collective security response is needed in the region. Together with regional actors, such as the African Union and the Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS), the United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel (UNOWAS) and the United Nations can play a key role in supporting a political environment conducive to enhanced security cooperation. A collective security response to the challenges facing the region could involve the development of a joint regional counter-terrorism strategy. This should build on the existing efforts of ECOWAS and on other regional initiatives, including the Multinational Joint Task Force. Any efforts to tackle terrorism must always be consistent with international humanitarian law and international human rights law.

Secondly, the challenges to peace and security in West Africa and the Sahel are increasingly complex. Challenges span from narrowing civic and political space to the troubling transnational organized crime and drug trafficking, as well as the increasingly dire consequences of climate change. These factors continue to contribute to a worsening of the humanitarian situation, including forced displacement and a lack of humanitarian access. Cross-border initiatives and regional collaboration are essential in addressing those multidimensional challenges to security and finding a shared path towards peace, a path that must be built on respect for international law, including humanitarian and international human rights law. We support ECOWAS in exercising its role as the primary regional actor addressing security challenges, in alignment with other regional and bilateral initiatives. We commend the initiative taken by Ghana and Togo to foster dialogue within the region,

and we strongly endorse the efforts by the African Union Mission for Mali and the Sahel and the African Union High Representative to convene actors and to lead dialogue. We must continue to build on such African-led efforts as part of strengthening the region's collective security response.

Thirdly, security measures alone cannot foster peace, resilience and prosperity. Political solutions are needed. In the Central Sahel, insecurity, weak governance and economic exclusion have contributed to the violation of human rights and the rule of law. We believe that sustainable peace can be built only on democratic principles of governance. Denmark calls for progress on transition processes and respect for the constitutional order and the rule of law. The United Nations has an important role to play in helping countries and communities to build trust and strengthen national prevention capacities. Denmark calls on all countries in the region to collaborate with the United Nations. As Special Representative Simão outlined, UNOWAS provides important support for regional cooperation, preventive diplomacy and inclusive, democratic governance, as well as the implementation of the women and peace and security agenda. We encourage continued efforts by the United Nations to ensure political commitment to regional and international cooperation from all actors. We also encourage UNOWAS to continue strengthening coherence and coordination with other United Nations agencies, funds and programmes.

The United Nations must be fit for purpose at this critical time for the region. We look forward to considering the findings on the ongoing independent strategic review of UNOWAS.

In conclusion, Denmark is a long-standing partner of West Africa and the Sahel. We will continue to cooperate with the region in pursuing collective solutions in areas of counterterrorism, peacebuilding, development cooperation and humanitarian aid.

Mr. Bartos (United States of America): I thank Special Representative Simão for his insightful briefing. We are grateful for his leadership and engagement across the region and look forward to receiving the United Nations strategic assessment of the United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel in the coming months.

As we meet today, terrorism continues to fundamentally disrupt and shatter the lives of millions of people across the Sahel and West Africa. The latest attacks are more sophisticated, more coordinated and are escalating in intensity. The United States condemns in the strongest terms all terrorist attacks, including the 25 April terrorist attack in Mali and the 18 June attack on the airport in Niamey. We express our deepest condolences to the families of those who were killed. There must be accountability for the attacks perpetrated by Al-Qaida-affiliated Jama'a Nusrat ul-Islam wa al-Muslimin, Islamic State in Iraq and the Sham Sahel, Islamic State West Africa Province, Boko Haram and all other terrorist groups operating across the region.

The Council should encourage greater coordination between the Confederation of Sahel States and their coastal neighbours. The current lack of coordination serves only the interests of the terrorist organizations operating in the region, as they eagerly exploit these political fractures. The United States remains committed to engaging constructively with all countries in the region.

Earlier this month, our Deputy Secretary of State met with the ambassadors of Burkina Faso, Mali and the Niger in Washington to reaffirm the United States' commitment to working with these countries based on respect for sovereignty and the advancement of mutual interests.

We continue to urge the Sahelian States and their coastal West African neighbours to set aside their differences and seek a unified, coordinated response to

terrorism — one that respects the rule of law and human rights and includes military cooperation and intelligence-sharing. African ownership of the regional security situation, with a coordinated response among all countries in the region, is critical. The United States, in turn, will continue to work with our regional partners to counter these common threats.

Finally, the ongoing crisis in the Sudan continues to have far-reaching impacts on peace and security across the Sahel. The United States calls on the belligerents in the Sudan to immediately commit to and comply with a humanitarian truce without conditions. There is no military solution to this conflict. The people of the Sudan cannot wait any longer and deserve better.

Mr. Alfaro de Alba (Panama) (*spoke in Spanish*): We would like to thank the presidency of the Democratic Republic of the Congo for convening this meeting. We thank Mr. Leonardo Santos Simão, Special Representative of the Secretary-General for West Africa and the Sahel, for his valuable contributions, good offices and sound leadership. We welcome the representatives of Côte d'Ivoire and Burkina Faso, whose participation honours us.

We recognize the efforts of the United Nations and regional actors, including the African Union, the Economic Community of West African States and the Confederation of Sahel States, and commend their willingness to engage in constructive dialogue to jointly address the challenges facing the region. Restoring trust among the actors and eradicating extremism at its roots are crucial to revitalizing the region and leading it towards sustainable peace and development.

We express our condolences to the victims of the terrorist attacks and to their families. Those attacks continue to devastate communities and undermine governments and regional stability.

Terrorism cannot be eradicated through military means — not in West Africa or anywhere else. Extremism can be eradicated through dialogue and by redirecting efforts to implement quality education policies and create economic, employment and social opportunities for young people. Extremists exploit young people's vulnerabilities and lack of opportunities in order to recruit them. However, evidence shows that if we invest in preventive social policies, we can end such recruitment and other forms of radicalization.We therefore support the Secretary-General's call in his report (S/2026/537) for investment in development, water management, food security and job creation. These are essential human rights that help address the root causes of conflict, safeguard human dignity and prevent violence.

We are pleased to note that, despite the destabilization attempts faced by some countries, elections have been held and transition processes have advanced in the region, as the Special Representative noted. These developments indicate progress in democracy and governance, both of which help stabilize the situation.

We recognize regional sovereignty and the sovereignty of African countries. We note with concern foreign interference in the region, in particular by actors that promote or might even fund armed groups and fuel the conflict in order to establish their influence and extract critical resources and minerals, including uranium, gold and oil.

We also note with concern the coordination observed in Mali between terrorist groups such as Jama'a Nusrat ul-Islam wa al-Muslimin and insurgent groups such as the Front de libération de l'Azawad. Financing networks for armed and terrorist groups are complex. Illicit resource extraction, drug trafficking and related markets help sustain these networks. Funding flows through those networks should therefore

be thoroughly traced from their origins to their destinations, and accountability should be pursued in accordance with the rule of law.

We call on all parties to keep diplomatic channels open and to ensure meaningful follow-up to the informal interactive dialogue held exactly one year ago with all relevant actors in the region. Unfortunately, the proposal arising from that dialogue to develop a joint regional strategy to eradicate extremism and terrorism has yet to materialize. Greater political will is needed to build momentum.

It is important that, as a Council, we draw on the information provided by the United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel and on its cooperation with the Economic Community of West African States and the Confederation of Sahel States to chart a course towards improving the well-being of the region's civilian population, which bears the brunt of our inaction.

We reiterate our support for Special Representative Simão's leadership of the Office, and we hope that the United Nations presence will continue to be used to prevent further conflict and mitigate volatility in the region.

Mr. Sun Lei (China) (*spoke in Chinese*): I thank Special Representative Simão for his briefing. China will continue to support the work of the United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel and of the Special Representative.

The situation in West Africa and the Sahel remains generally stable, with steady economic growth, but many challenges remain. The international community should devote greater attention and resources to help countries in the region address governance, security and development challenges and consolidate the hard-won positive momentum.

I would like to make three points in that regard.

First, we must spare no effort to safeguard political stability in the region. During the reporting period, countries in the region steadily advanced their political processes. Benin and Cabo Verde held peaceful elections, while Nigeria and the Gambia have been actively preparing for general elections. Many countries achieved tangible progress in constitutional, electoral and governance reforms. The international community should continue to support countries in the region as they prepare for elections, consolidate the gains of political transitions, build governance capacity and explore development paths suited to their national conditions.

China welcomes the active engagement of Mali, Burkina Faso and the Niger, in dialogue with the African Union and the Economic Community of West African States, and encourages all parties concerned to continue communicating candidly, build mutual trust, dispel doubts, bridge differences and deepen cooperation, thereby injecting more positive energy into political stability in the region.

Secondly, we must continue to strengthen coordinated regional counter-terrorism efforts. The counter-terrorism situation in the Sahel has become increasingly complex and severe. Terrorist groups have intensified their attacks and infiltration into countries in the Central Sahel, with increasingly sophisticated weapons and tactics. The recent and accelerating trend of convergence between terrorist organizations and separatist armed groups in Mali warrants high vigilance. China firmly opposes terrorism in all its forms and strongly condemns attacks by terrorist organizations or individuals against civilians and critical infrastructure. Countries in the region must continue to strengthen security cooperation in border control, intelligence-sharing and joint counter-terrorism efforts; improve regional collective defence arrangements; and enhance their capacity to independently address security risks. Various counter-terrorism mechanisms should strengthen coordination and collaboration to generate effective counter-terrorism synergy. The international

community should provide support in funding, equipment and technology to help countries in the region strengthen their security capabilities.

Thirdly, we must comprehensively strengthen the foundations of regional development. For a long time, weak economic foundations, insufficient food production capacity and high youth unemployment have continuously eroded the region's development resilience, creating conditions conducive to instability. We should adopt a holistic approach that addresses both the symptoms and the root causes of these issues. While providing humanitarian assistance and alleviating livelihood difficulties, we must increase investment in modern agriculture, food security, youth employment and infrastructure, so as to address development shortcomings and unleash endogenous growth, thereby consolidating the gains of peace through sustainable development.

China is a sincere friend and reliable partner to the countries of West Africa and the Sahel. Under such frameworks as the Forum on China-Africa Cooperation, China stands ready to continue deepening practical cooperation with countries in the region across various fields, continuously enhance the people's sense of gain, happiness and security and make greater contributions to promoting lasting peace, development and prosperity in the region.

Mr. Bonnafont (France) (*spoke in French*): At the outset, I would like to thank the Special Representative, Mr. Leonardo Santos Simão, for his remarks and his vital work in facilitating dialogue in the region.

As the Special Representative of the Secretary-General said, the security situation in the region continues to deteriorate, and this is having terrible humanitarian consequences, with more than 6,800,000 internally displaced persons. This situation — exacerbated by difficulties in gaining access and the underfunding of the humanitarian response — is undermining the resilience of civilian populations and having a disproportionate impact on women and girls.

As I have said before, the reason for this alarming humanitarian situation is, as the Secretary-General highlights in his report (S/2026/537), the security challenge affecting the region and beyond. The Central Sahel and the Lake Chad basin, in particular, continue to face unsustainable terrorist violence, which France condemns in the strongest possible terms. In the Sahel in particular, Jama'a Nusrat ul-Islam wa al-Muslimin is gradually strengthening its territorial control, as demonstrated by the attacks at the end of April, which were condemned by the Council, and the ambush on a Malian army convoy two days ago. This development, coupled with the lack of an appropriate collective response from the international community, poses a heightened threat to the entire region.

To address the deteriorating security and humanitarian situation and find regional solutions to shared challenges, it is necessary to work towards stability in this region and to promote dialogue. France welcomes the efforts made in this regard by the African Union, the Economic Community of West African States and several African States. The United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel (UNOWAS) also plays an important role through its good offices and its new mission of promoting respect for constitutional order. Indeed, it is essential to develop good governance practices throughout the region in order to build more resilient societies. Institutions must be strengthened, and political, civic and media spaces must be safeguarded, so as to make democratic expression possible and effectively combat disinformation and hate speech. UNOWAS can provide valuable assistance to the States of the region in that regard.

France has advocated, in the context of the renewal of UNOWAS's mandate, for the Council to maintain an ambitious and regular dialogue with West African States

through an increased number of reports and meetings each year. The grave nature of the events observed in recent weeks and months underscores the importance of this approach. It is important for the Council to continue to pay regular attention to this region and its people, who are facing unprecedented challenges.

France remains committed to supporting the Council's dialogue with States in the region that wish to benefit from the international community's support. It welcomes the renewal of UNOWAS's mandate for three years. It welcomes the independent review entrusted to President Sahle-Work Zewde and calls on all Council members to do likewise. The Security Council cannot and must not look the other way.

Mr. Alrowaiei (Bahrain) (*spoke in Arabic*): I am pleased to thank Mr. Leonardo Simão, Special Representative of the Secretary-General and Head of the United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel, for his valuable briefing. We commend the Office's efforts to support dialogue, regional coordination and the promotion of peace and stability in the region, and we reaffirm the support of the Kingdom of Bahrain for its mandate. We also welcome the participation of the representatives of Côte d'Ivoire and Burkina Faso.

We thank the Secretary-General for his report (S/2026/537) and for the comprehensive assessment of developments in West Africa and the Sahel contained therein. We would like to highlight the following points.

First, the Kingdom of Bahrain welcomes the positive signs observed in West Africa and the Sahel, in particular the holding of elections, the ongoing reform efforts and political dialogue and the progress made in the dialogue between the Economic Community of West African States and the Confederation of Sahel States. We believe that these developments constitute an important opportunity to strengthen trust and regional cooperation, thereby helping to consolidate security and stability, based on the Kingdom's firm conviction that dialogue is the best way to address common challenges.

Secondly, despite the positive signs, security threats remain a cause for serious concern in the region, against the backdrop of the continuing deterioration of security infrastructure, the growing capabilities of terrorist groups and the expansion of their operations across a number of countries in West Africa and the Sahel. The recent coordinated terrorist attacks in the Republic of Mali underscored the seriousness of this trend and what it reflects in terms of the growing capabilities of terrorist groups and the increasing coordination among these groups, thereby imperilling the security and stability of the entire region. In this regard, the Kingdom of Bahrain reaffirms its unwavering condemnation of terrorism in all its forms and manifestations and emphasizes the importance of strengthening security and intelligence cooperation, drying up the financial, ideological and organizational sources of terrorism, implementing the relevant Security Council resolutions and fully respecting the sovereignty of States and their national ownership of these efforts.

Thirdly, humanitarian and economic challenges have become more pressing, as ongoing conflicts, widespread displacement, declining humanitarian funding and food insecurity are undermining efforts to achieve stability and development. The Kingdom of Bahrain therefore emphasizes the importance of strengthening international support, ensuring unimpeded access to humanitarian and relief aid and investing in people by empowering women and young people and strengthening their role in peacebuilding, thereby supporting sustainable security and stability.

In conclusion, the Kingdom of Bahrain reaffirms its commitment to supporting all international and regional efforts aimed at consolidating security, stability and sustainable development in West Africa and the Sahel and at strengthening

partnerships that enable the peoples of the region to address common challenges and build a more secure and prosperous future.

Ms. Evstigneeva (Russian Federation) (*spoke in Russian*): We thank Special Representative of the Secretary-General for West Africa and the Sahel Leonardo Simão for presenting the report (S/2026/537) on the current state of affairs in the region. We support the work of the Office as part of its mandate.

We are following developments in the region closely. We note with concern the increasing infiltration of terrorists from the Sahel into the coastal States of the Gulf of Guinea, the heightened coordination among the various groups and the extent to which they are being equipped technologically and resourced. The surge in militant activity in Nigeria is also a cause for concern, where 1,258 civilians were killed in the period from 1 January to 10 February alone. The full extent of the capabilities of the terrorist groups operating in the Sahel became apparent during the armed clashes with terrorists in Mali that began on 25 April. It became clear that the militants are capable of carrying out simultaneous, large-scale attacks on the country's largest cities and possess the necessary financial and technical resources to do so. The Security Council gave an assessment of these events in a press statement of 15 May (SC/16360), which Russia supported. The statement explicitly describes that these attacks carried out by the Jama'a Nusrat ul-Islam wa al-Muslimin and the Front de libération de l'Azawad are terrorist in nature. In addition, the latest report of the Secretary-General further documents the civilian and military casualties that ensued from these attacks. We express our condolences to the Government of the Republic of Mali on the death of the country's Minister of Defence, Sadio Camara, who personally fought the terrorists who attacked his home in the city of Kati. We note the decision by transitional President Assimi Goïta to head the Republic's Ministry of Defence at this difficult time. It is telling that, in his televised address on 28 April, President Goïta explicitly pointed to the involvement of external sponsors in the coordinated terrorist attack on Bamako and the country's major cities. We concur with that assessment.

It is obvious that these and other destructive acts were planned and carried out with the direct involvement of external forces, who, short-sightedly, are labouring under the illusion that they will always be able to control terrorists. There is information about the Kyiv regime's support for the armed groups. Information on the supply of unmanned aerial vehicles and the training of militants by Ukrainian military instructors has been confirmed. At the same time, it is also astonishing that, against that backdrop of the Security Council's condemnation of the terrorist activities of the Jama'a Nusrat ul-Islam wa al-Muslimin and the Front de libération de l'Azawad and the atrocities they committed, which received widespread media coverage, representatives of the Front are giving interviews in Paris. We are gravely concerned that, amid calls for effective regional counter-terrorism cooperation, members of these groups are being welcomed in Europe.

It comes as no surprise to us that, once again, terrorists decided to put their strength to the test in northern Mali in early July. Their attacks near Aguelhok and Anéfis were repulsed. The groups suffered significant losses. Just as they did in April, on this occasion the Malian armed forces and the Russian Africa Corps served as a bulwark against terrorist attacks. For its part, the Russian Federation will continue to provide effective assistance to the Sahel States in their fight against terrorism. Given developments in the security situation in the Sahel, we consider it fitting to recall that Mali, the Niger and Burkina Faso are at the forefront of efforts to combat trans-African terrorist groups. Now more than ever, they deserve the support of the international community and regional organizations. In this respect, we are perplexed at the refusal of Western members of the Security Council to explicitly mention the

name “Confederation of Sahel States” in Security Council documents. One can pretend as much as one likes that the Confederation does not exist, but this will not reduce the terrorist threat in the region.

We welcome the attitude, noted in the report, on the part of members of the Confederation of Sahel States and the Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS) towards the gradual restoration of relations on a mutually beneficial basis. We note the positive decisions in this regard adopted following the meeting of ECOWAS leaders on 14 December 2025 in Abuja. Collective efforts are key to effectively countering the growing terrorist threat in the region. We agree with the report’s assessment regarding ECOWAS’s consistent efforts to reinforce stability within ECOWAS. At the request of the Government of Benin, the ECOWAS reaction force was deployed to Benin in December and succeeded in thwarting an attempted coup. Following the presidential elections in Guinea in December, the country’s participation in the work of ECOWAS bodies resumed.

We greatly appreciate the active endeavours of Special Representative of the Secretary-General Leonardo Simão in bolstering trust in the region and fostering conditions conducive to dialogue among countries with a view to overcoming existing security and development-related challenges. We are satisfied with the results of the work of the Cameroon-Nigeria Mixed Commission, as part of which the complex process of demarcating the relevant State boundary is nearing completion.

We note the ongoing review of the United Nations integrated strategy for the Sahel. We believe that this process will enable useful lessons to be drawn from the numerous, albeit not always effective, efforts undertaken previously, and will allow the United Nations to focus its activities on addressing key challenges for the region, including in the field of sustainable development, and to develop a set of support measures that factor in regional interests.

We reaffirm our principled stance in defence of the sovereignty, unity and territorial integrity of all countries in the region.

We call on the international community to provide consolidated support to the Confederation of Sahel States, which, through no fault of its own, has found itself at the forefront of the fight against the mounting threat of terrorism. We are convinced that this will be facilitated by, among other measures, constructive dialogue among the African Union and the Economic Community of West African States with the Sahel troika. For our part, we will continue to make a constructive contribution towards stability in the region. We will continue to provide assistance to the Sahel States on a bilateral and multilateral basis, including in enhancing the combat capability of their national armed forces.

Ms. Pavļuta-Deslandes (Latvia): I thank Special Representative of the Secretary-General Leonardo Santos Simão for his briefing.

I would like to make three points.

First, terrorism in the Sahel is evolving faster than our collective response. The Sahel remains among the world’s regions most affected by terrorism, accounting for more than half of the terrorism-related deaths globally. The threat is increasingly extending to its neighbouring coastal States. And terrorist groups, including Jama’a Nusrat ul-Islam wa al-Muslimin and regional affiliates of Da’esh, continue to expand their reach, to deepen ties with organized crime networks and to exploit porous borders, governance vacuums, socioeconomic vulnerabilities and illicit trafficking and financial flows. A series of coordinated attacks across Mali have demonstrated the ability of these groups to strike simultaneously across multiple fronts. Similarly, repeated attacks targeting Diori Hamani International Airport in Niamey during the

six months of this year illustrate their capacity to conduct complex operations against strategic infrastructure, including in urban areas. Latvia condemns in the strongest terms the heinous terrorist attacks and stands in full solidarity with the peoples of West Africa and the Sahel.

Alongside terrorism, ongoing violence and conflict, political instability and climate-related shocks have resulted in the displacement of 6.8 million people across the region, as we have heard. Worsening humanitarian conditions and severely constrained access have deprived millions of life-saving assistance and left growing numbers of people increasingly vulnerable.

Moreover, terrorist groups in the region are adapting their means and methods of attack, including through the increased use of emerging technologies and commercial satellites. That extends their operational reach and enhances their ability to coordinate attacks across borders. It also facilitates the financing of terrorism through cryptocurrencies and the spread of propaganda and disinformation.

Countering terrorism in West Africa and the Sahel therefore requires stronger regional coordination, supported by the United Nations and international partners, as well as practical cooperation among governments, civil society and the private sector. It is essential to disrupt terrorist financing and criminal networks, strengthen border management and improve intelligence-sharing. Moreover, all counter-terrorism efforts should be grounded in respect for international law, including international humanitarian law and international human rights law.

Secondly, it is essential to maintain dialogue, despite political differences. Latvia welcomes recent efforts by the Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS), the African Union and regional leaders to preserve channels of communication and rebuild trust. They include the ECOWAS appointment of Lansana Kouyaté as chief negotiator for engagement with the countries of the Confederation of Sahel States, the African Union's strengthened engagement through its mission in Mali and the Sahel and efforts by Ghana and Togo to reopen dialogue between the coastal and central Sahel States.

We encourage Burkina Faso, Mali and the Niger to remain open to practical regional cooperation, including with ECOWAS and the African Union. Latvia reiterates its firm conviction that the United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel (UNOWAS) plays an indispensable role in facilitating political dialogue, strengthening regional cooperation and advancing conflict prevention. We strongly encourage all countries of the region to leverage UNOWAS as a vital platform for practical engagement on compounding security and governance challenges, and we look forward to the strategic review of UNOWAS being conducted by Her Excellency Ms. Sahle-Work Zewde.

Thirdly, investing in youth and women is one of the most effective ways to strengthen security over the long term. Since approximately 65 per cent of the Sahel's population is under the age of 30, young people must be empowered as agents of peace and resilience, rather than becoming targets of extremist recruitment. Developing education, livelihoods, effective institutions and local governance is an investment in long-term stability and resilience. It provides opportunities and support for meaningful civic participation. We welcome the fact that UNOWAS systematically integrates the women and peace and security agenda, because true security cannot be achieved without addressing the disproportionate impact of conflict on women and girls. Ensuring the full, equal and meaningful participation of women is an operational prerequisite for long-term stability.

Lastly, regional ownership, backed by sustained international support, remains the only path to lasting peace in the region. The people of West Africa and the Sahel

have demonstrated remarkable resilience, and the Security Council must remain fully engaged. Together, we will break the cycle of violence, and we are committed to doing so.

Mr. Ahmad (Pakistan): I would like to thank Special Representative Simão for his comprehensive briefing, which was structured around the three broad trends that he outlined. We appreciate the continued efforts of the United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel (UNOWAS) in fostering inclusive political dialogue, supporting preventive diplomacy and promoting regional cooperation across West Africa and the Sahel. We look forward to the forthcoming independent strategic review of UNOWAS.

The Secretary-General's latest report on the activities of UNOWAS (S/2026/537) presents a region that is facing complex political, security, humanitarian, socioeconomic and other challenges, while also highlighting positive developments, such as renewed efforts at regional dialogue between the Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS) and the Confederation of Sahel States and other initiatives aimed at strengthening regional cooperation.

Against that background, allow me to make four points.

First, Pakistan reaffirms its steadfast commitment to the independence, sovereignty and territorial integrity of the countries of the region and to the principle of non-interference in the internal affairs of States. Pakistan's partnership with Africa is long-standing, deep-rooted and wide-ranging. Pakistani peacekeepers have served with distinction across the African continent, contributing to the United Nations peacekeeping and peacebuilding efforts in various countries. We firmly believe that durable solutions entail national ownership, coordinated regional responses and constructive international engagement and support. In that vein, discussions in the Council could, in our view, be more productive if there were enhanced participation by the countries of the region and regional and subregional organizations. In that regard, we welcome the participation of Côte d'Ivoire and Burkina Faso in today's meeting.

Secondly, the grave terrorist threat across West Africa and the Sahel, exemplified by the coordinated terrorist attacks in Mali, the Niger and elsewhere, remains a foremost concern and underscores the need for sustained regional and international cooperation. Countering terrorism and violent extremism requires a comprehensive strategy that combines effective security responses with measures to address their root causes.

Thirdly, strengthening regional cooperation remains indispensable. In that regard, we welcome the engagement between ECOWAS and the Confederation of Sahel States and encourage continued dialogue aimed at rebuilding trust and enhancing collective responses to shared challenges.

Fourthly, the international community must remain engaged in addressing the region's broader humanitarian and development challenges. Persistent funding shortfalls that continue to undermine the humanitarian response must be addressed. Lasting peace and security is linked to sustainable development, resilient institutions and expanded economic opportunities.

Let me conclude by reaffirming Pakistan's continued commitment to supporting all initiatives aimed at advancing peace and stability in the region.

Ms. Jambert-Gray (United Kingdom): I thank Special Representative Simão for his informative briefing today.

I will make three points.

First, we remain concerned about the deteriorating security and humanitarian situation across West Africa and the Sahel. We condemn the recent coordinated attacks in Mali, which demonstrate an alarming increase in the sophistication, coordination and reach of terrorist and armed groups in the country.

In addition, humanitarian needs across the region remain severe. As the Special Representative set out, approximately 6.8 million people remain displaced in the Sahel. We call for full, safe, rapid and unhindered humanitarian access to those in need. The United Kingdom is supporting efforts through $232 million of assistance throughout the region.

Secondly, we welcome the peaceful conduct of elections in Benin, Cabo Verde, Côte d'Ivoire and Guinea. However, we remain concerned about the lack of opposition participation, the shrinking of political and civic space and the concentration of executive authority in parts of the region. Inclusive political processes, accountable institutions and credible elections are essential to long-term stability. We encourage all actors to work with the United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel to support dialogue, uphold constitutional governance and ensure transparent and inclusive political processes.

Thirdly, we welcome efforts to strengthen cooperation between the Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS) and the Confederation of Sahel States, including the ECOWAS appointment of a chief negotiator to help restore dialogue. We encourage continued engagement to rebuild trust and address shared challenges. Enhanced cooperation on counter-terrorism, border management and organized crime is critical to improving regional security and stability.

To conclude, the United Kingdom remains committed to working closely with the United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel and regional partners to support peace, stability and prosperity across West Africa and the Sahel.

Mrs. Zalabata Torres (Colombia) (*spoke in Spanish*): I would like to thank the Secretary-General's Special Representative, Leonardo Santos Simão, for his briefing, which reflects the multidimensional nature of the challenges facing the countries of West Africa and the Sahel. In this regard, I would like to highlight four points.

First, the Colombian Government unreservedly condemns the terrorism and violent extremism affecting millions of people in the region. Faced with actors who are expanding their cross-border influence, employing increasingly sophisticated methods and gaining the capacity to impose blockades or control territories, dialogue, coordination and cooperation are the only alternatives to respond effectively to these threats. In this regard, Colombia welcomes and encourages efforts and initiatives to strengthen trust and joint action among the countries of the region, including the appointment by the Economic Community of West African States of Mr. Lansana Kouyaté as chief negotiator with the Confederation of Sahel States.

Secondly, Colombia recognizes the diverse paths taken by the countries of West Africa and the Sahel towards peace and the consolidation of the rule of law and reaffirms the centrality of constitutional processes and respect for human rights. The Government of Colombia calls for no reversal in the progress achieved in a region that has witnessed the long-term benefits of peace processes, transitional justice and reconciliation. In this regard, Colombia expresses its concern at restrictions on the exercise of civil and political rights and emphasizes the importance of opening up spaces for dialogue and participation for civil society and communities, especially by promoting the effective participation of women and young people. In this vein, we highlight the exchange of experiences between women peacebuilders from Colombia and West Africa and the Sahel. Colombia has reiterated in the Council its willingness to draw on its experience to inspire and contribute to peace efforts around the world.

Thirdly, it is essential to prioritize a holistic approach that incorporates sustainable development, governance, human rights and humanitarian dimensions, and that tackles the structural causes of violence. In this regard, Colombia expresses its concern at the complex humanitarian situation and calls for full respect for international norms prohibiting all forms of violence against the civilian population. Furthermore, the Government of Colombia emphasizes the exacerbating effects of climate change on the humanitarian situation, as well as the resulting intercommunal tensions and the impact on livelihoods. We therefore welcome the efforts of the United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel to promote water diplomacy in the region as a means of conflict prevention and cross-border cooperation.

Similarly, the Government of Colombia highlights the importance of inclusive development policies that address the specific needs of women, girls and young people, who are disproportionately affected by conflict situations in the region. We therefore recognize the efforts of the Office and the countries of the region to advance the implementation of the women and peace and security and youth, peace and security agendas, which are the best tools at our disposal for reducing vulnerabilities, guaranteeing rights and promoting the participation of these groups. At the same time, my delegation acknowledges the difficulties arising from limited fiscal space and once again echoes the Secretary-General's call to reform the international financial architecture. No country should have to choose between investing in its people and paying high debt servicing costs.

Fourthly and finally, Colombia emphasizes the importance of the United Nations Office for West Africa. The Organization must maintain sustained political engagement, making full use of its convening power and supporting regional efforts to restore constitutional order and address shared challenges. Colombia welcomes the renewal of the Office's mandate and stands ready to contribute to the forthcoming strategic review process.

The Colombian Government is aware of the challenges posed by the long and far from straightforward path to peace and will resolutely support regional efforts to build and consolidate a sustainable peace in West Africa and the Sahel.

Mrs. Balta (Greece) (*spoke in French*): I thank you, Mr. President, for convening this meeting. I would like to thank Special Representative Leonardo Santos Simão for his comprehensive briefing and commend the United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel for its tireless work in a particularly difficult regional context.

(*spoke in English*)

Allow me to highlight three points.

First, the security situation remains deeply concerning. The coordinated terrorist attacks in Mali last April marked a dangerous escalation, while continued attacks by Jama'a Nusrat ul-Islam wa al-Muslimin, Islamic State in the Greater Sahara and Boko Haram across Mali, the Niger, Burkina Faso, Nigeria and Benin reflect the growing operational capabilities of terrorist groups across the region. The attempted coup in Benin last December further exposed the fragility of the regional security environment. No country can confront these threats alone. Greece, therefore, welcomes the renewed momentum towards dialogue between the Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS) and the Confederation of Sahel States and the appointment of Mr. Lansana Kouyaté as chief negotiator.

We also commend the progress towards operationalizing regional counter-terrorism arrangements, including the ECOWAS Counter-Terrorism Force, as well as ECOWAS' decision to provide financial support to coastal States facing increasing

terrorist spillover. We fully endorse the communiqué adopted by the ECOWAS Authority last December, calling for renewed security cooperation with the Central Sahel and continued implementation of resolution 2719 (2023), as a key framework for predictable and sustainable support to African Union-led peace support operations. Strengthened maritime security cooperation in the Gulf of Guinea, including through the Yaoundé Architecture, should complement these efforts, as security in the Central Sahel and the coastal States is increasingly interconnected.

Secondly, on the political front, Greece welcomes the peaceful conclusion of the electoral processes in Benin and Cabo Verde. We particularly commend Cabo Verde for the election of the first woman to lead its parliament, an important milestone for inclusive governance. We also encourage continued preparations for the upcoming elections in Nigeria and the Gambia. Across the region, political transitions should remain anchored in transparent, inclusive and peaceful electoral processes, conducted in accordance with agreed timelines and with the participation of all relevant stakeholders. This remains particularly important in countries undergoing political transitions, including Guinea-Bissau, in which dialogue and broad national ownership will be essential for restoring constitutional order and lasting stability.

My third point is on human rights, humanitarian assistance and climate resilience. Greece remains deeply concerned about the disproportionate impact of conflict on children, including attacks on schools, abductions and recruitment and use of children by armed groups, and reiterates the importance of ensuring their protection and safe access to education. We remain equally concerned that women continue to face insecurity, sexual and gender-based violence and barriers to political participation. While we welcome regional efforts to strengthen women's leadership, including ECOWAS's commitment to increasing women's representation in elected bodies to 50 per cent by 2035, much more remains to be done.

Addressing these challenges also requires adequate humanitarian support. Yet the Secretary-General reports that only 14 per cent of the funding required for the 2026 humanitarian response had been received by the end of April. Bridging this funding gap is essential to assist the millions affected by conflict, displacement and food insecurity. At the same time, greater investment in climate resilience is equally important to address the underlying drivers of instability that compound existing security and humanitarian challenges.

In closing, Greece remains committed to supporting the region through effective multilateralism and close partnership with the United Nations, the African Union, ECOWAS and all regional stakeholders, firmly grounded in African ownership and African-led solutions, in pursuit of lasting peace, security and sustainable development.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Côte d'Ivoire.

Mr. Moriko (Côte d'Ivoire) (*spoke in French*): My country would like to extend its warm congratulations to the Democratic Republic of the Congo on the remarkable manner in which the Congolese delegation has steered the Council's work since assuming the presidency. Côte d'Ivoire assures you, Mr. President, of its full support in the fulfilment of your important duties. My delegation thanks the Secretary-General for his report on the activities of the United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel (UNOWAS) (S/2026/537). We also thank the Special Representative, Mr. Leonardo Santos Simão, for his unwavering commitment to peace and stability in West Africa and the Sahel.

Côte d'Ivoire notes with satisfaction the holding of peaceful elections in several countries in the region, as well as initiatives aimed at restoring dialogue, trust and

cooperation among West African States. In this regard, my country commends the efforts of the Economic Community of West African States, the African Union and UNOWAS to foster closer ties between the coastal and landlocked States of the region. In the face of these shared challenges, unity of action within our region is of the utmost importance.

Côte d'Ivoire, which is hosting more than 105,000 refugees and asylum seekers as a result of the regional security situation, remains deeply concerned about the spread and humanitarian consequences of the terrorist threat, the increasing sophistication of attacks, the use of drones and improvised explosive devices and the links between armed groups and transnational criminal networks. My delegation reaffirms that the fight against terrorism requires a collective response based on intelligence-sharing, cross-border cooperation, the pooling of capabilities and sustainable funding for an African security mechanism.

A military response alone will not suffice. Poverty, youth unemployment, the effects of climate change, forced displacement, inadequate social services and the growing burden of debt are all factors that contribute to fragility. Côte d'Ivoire therefore considers it necessary to invest more in prevention, local governance, the resilience of border areas, the empowerment of young people and women and the funding of humanitarian and development action. My delegation also supports the Secretary-General's call for reform of the international financial architecture, so as to enable countries in the region to devote more resources to their populations and to the achievement of the Sustainable Development Goals.

Côte d'Ivoire reaffirms its full support for UNOWAS's mandate and its good offices, which are essential to preventing crises, promoting dialogue and supporting regional efforts towards peace and stability. My country remains fully committed to a united, resilient and prosperous West Africa built on solidarity, mutual trust and shared responsibility.

Before concluding, my delegation would like, in a constructive spirit, to make a clarification pertaining to paragraph 7 of the report. The main opposition political parties did participate in the parliamentary elections of 27 December 2025 in Côte d'Ivoire, with the exception of the Parti des peuples africains – Côte d'Ivoire, which chose not to take part in the elections. My delegation would be grateful if the Secretariat could reflect this factual correction to the report.

The President (*spoke in French*): I now give the floor to the representative of Burkina Faso.

Mr. Zongo (Burkina Faso) (*spoke in French*): Since this is the first time that Burkina Faso has taken the floor during your presidency, I would like to offer you, Mr. President, our warmest congratulations and wish you every success during your presidency of the Security Council for the month of July. I would also like to thank Mr. Leonardo Simão, Special Representative of the Secretary-General for West Africa and the Sahel, for his presentation of the report. In addition, we would like to thank all the members of the Security Council who, once again, have condemned the terrorist attacks in the Sahel and expressed their solidarity with the peoples of the Sahel.

Burkina Faso is pleased to be taking part in this meeting to discuss the Office's activities over the past four months. We took careful note of the contents of the report (S/2026/537) and, for the sake of clarity, would like to provide some additional information so as to further enlighten the Council.

With regard to security issues, we would like to emphasize that Burkina Faso makes enormous efforts on a daily basis to guarantee its national security. The report

does, in fact, mention this in relation to increasing defence and security personnel. These efforts have enabled progress to be made towards regaining control of territory and are making a significant contribution to the fight against terrorism being waged by Burkina Faso, alongside its brothers in Mali and Niger, within the framework of the Confederation of Sahel States. The establishment and operationalization of a joint military force within the Confederation of Sahel States demonstrates our common determination to tackle security challenges through concrete regional cooperation.

With regard to humanitarian concerns, we commend the resilience of the people of the Sahel, who are facing their challenges with dignity. We commend the efforts of humanitarian partners for their support. Burkina Faso will continue to make the necessary efforts to escort convoys and ensure security for humanitarian organizations in hard-to-reach areas.

On the issue of human rights, the suspension and subsequent dissolution of associations at the national level as mentioned in the report — far from being a setback in the promotion of human rights — are measures with the sole aim of bringing the voluntary sector into line with the law and serving as a reminder of the need to comply with national law in this area.

The measures concerning humanitarian non-governmental organizations fall within the same category of security concerns and cannot be interpreted as acts of deliberate restriction. Burkina Faso would like to assure the Security Council that all measures currently in place in Burkina Faso are governed by the regulatory framework and are being taken in the context of the fight against terrorism. These measures aim to protect the population and guarantee the survival of a nation under attack.

We would like to commend all the efforts made to draft these highly constructive reports. They ease tensions and strengthen trust between the United Nations and the countries concerned. For us, it is important that the reports yield beneficial outcomes in terms of solutions for our subregion. For countries such as ours, the domestic situation must be assessed in the light of the highly disruptive factor of terrorism, which underscores the need to contextualize the data in order to provide a more nuanced perspective. We say this because certain issues raised did not exist when our three countries were not facing terrorism. This terrorism, as the Special Representative underscored, has become even more complex with the use of drones and other sophisticated means. This attests, of course, to the complicity of State entities in supporting terrorist organizations that are plunging our families in the Sahel into mourning. Burkina Faso remains convinced that the Security Council will take all these nuances into account in its analysis of the situation prevailing in the Sahel. The people of the Sahel are already suffering from terrorism and do not deserve to endure further tragedies. It is in this context that we make this appeal to the Security Council.

As the Special Representative so aptly noted, efforts in the region are currently under way that should be encouraged, as they will help to build trust among the countries of the region. We welcome this new development, as it is only in this way that, together, we will succeed in combating terrorism. Burkina Faso and the countries of the Confederation of Sahel States have faith in the future. We have already taken up the fight and, together with our people, will continue to demonstrate great resilience. The Confederation is open to dialogue, and we welcome all ongoing efforts to bridge differences, particularly the initiatives undertaken by Togo, the African Union and the United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel.

I would also like to take this opportunity to thank all friendly countries and sincere partners, who continue to support the Confederation in its fight against

terrorism. As was previously emphasized, terrorists now possess sophisticated capabilities and employ drones through highly complex coordination, thereby demonstrating the complicity of State entities in the commission of these attacks against the populations in our subregion.

In conclusion, Burkina Faso would like to reiterate its willingness to ensure that the United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel remains a tool to provide guidance and support to States and to undertake specific steps to ensure comprehensive security in our subregion. We hope that the views expressed today will contribute to a more comprehensive understanding of the realities of our subregion.

The President (*spoke in French*): There are no more names inscribed on the list of speakers. I now invite Council members to informal consultations to continue our discussion on the subject.

The meeting rose at 12.25 p.m.